A Simple Mech Subsystem

Much of this is adapted from the ATV rules in *Across the Bright Face*. See https://mtb-za.github.io/says-who/thoughts/2026/06/ct_mechs/.

Basics

Mechs are a type of vehicle and use the Vehicle (Mech) cascade skill. While a variety of designs exist, most are about 10 tons in weight and about 4-5m tall. They can travel at about 80km/hr consistently, with only extremely rough terrain slowing them down. They normally have only a single pilot.

Mechs are generally a little complicated and finnicky. They require four hours of maintenance once a week or after any combat in which a hit is taken. Maintenance is a mechanics throw; failing the throw (or not doing maintenance) penalises any DMs by 1 per missed maintenance window until more maintenance can be done.

Power

Power is supplied by a miniaturised version of a ship-style hydrogen powerplant. This has 50 power points (PP) when fully fueled. Life support requires 1PP/hr in most situations; extreme temperatures may consume more. Movement costs 1PP/hr in normal terrain, 2PP/hr in very rough terrain. Movement in combat requires 1PP/turn, but will move 1 range-band extra for each extra PP spent, up to 3. The mech can be refuelled using standard starship fuel, or more slowly, from sizeable amounts of ice or water in the environment.

Weapons

Standard armament is a large laser. The number of PP devoted to firing affects the hit probability. Each PP used after the first adds +1 to the hit throw.

Some mechs are equipped with a large-calibre multi-barrelled gun instead. This takes no appreciable power to fire, but only carries 10 combat rounds of ammunition. Reloading takes 15 minutes and some lifting equipment due to the weight (~350 kgs for a full load). This weapon follows the normal rules for multiple hits and multiple targets with automatic weapons in book 1.

Should mech weapons be removed, they are not usable without a mount and various connections to a fixed power supply.

See the weapon tables for the details of these.

Most mech models will only have a single weapon and any deviations (multiple weapons, different armaments, &c) are at the referee's discretion. Some obvious room for expansion is with Book 4 weapons or an anti-personnel mech with a bettery of normal weapons. For adapting weapons, make the close DM worse and the long-range DM a bit better and add a damage die to represent the larger scale of the weaponry involved.

Weapon	Nothing	Jack	Mesh	Cloth	Reflec	Ablat	Combat
Mech Laser	+4	+3	+2	+2	−6	−5	−5
Mech Gun	+8	+7	+1	0	+6	+3	−1

Weapon	Close	Short	Medium	Long	Very Long	Wounds
Mech Laser	−5	−1	+2	+2	+1	6D
Mech Gun	−10	−1	+3	+3	0	5D

Defences

Mechs are armoured, and most infantry-portable weapons (small arms) will do little damage. Most mechs can be treated as having combat armour, making effective hits difficult to land.

For every 20 damage taken from small arms, make one roll on the damage table. Ignore any results that are not Gun, Visor, or Module. Exceptions may be made for weapons intended to handle armoured targets (anti-tank missiles, FGMPs, other mech weapons, &c): these roll on the damage table for any effective hit.

Should mechs have multiple modules or weapons, choose exactly which is hit randomly or move down the list, but try and be consistent.

d6	Front	Side	Rear
1	Breach	Breach	Breach
2	Visor	Fuel	Fuel
3	Motor	Motor	Motor
4	Gun	Power	Power
5	Gun	Gun	Hatch
6	Module	Module	Module

- **Breach**: Armour damage. Life support cost is increased by 1PP/hr. Patching repressurises mech in about 30 minutes, normalising. Roll 2D. On a 2 the pilot has been hit for 1/2 damage of the inflicting weapon. On each subsequent hit, add 1 to the target for the injury throw.
- **Fuel**: Fuel tank leak. Lose half of the remaining fuel on each hit (halving remaining PP). A third hit leaves the vehicle unpowered.
- **Gun**: Damage to mech's weapon, halving damage output. A second hit disables it.
- **Hatch**: Jammed entry hatch. Escaping the mech will take a successful Mechanic throw or some other means of forcing the hatch open.
- **Module**: Damage to a module. The first hit halves any effects or otherwise degrades performance. The second hit disables it. Some modules may need a throw to not catastrophically fail. Small arms may be able to damage externally mounted modules.
- **Motor**: Limb control motor damaged, halving movement speed (pay extra PP/move in combat).

A second hit prevents any movement until repaired.
- **Power**: Damaged powerplant. All power costs are doubled. A second hit disables the plant. When disabled, make a 2D throw (and again if this is hit again). On a result of 2, the powerplant fails catastrophically.
- **Visor**: Damaged cockpit viewport. Any DMs relying on vision (including to-hit throws) by the mech are worsened by 2. Additional hits to the visor are treated as a *Breach*.

Worked Examples

The following are some common mech designs in the [redacted] Sector.

A Common Modules

Most mechs will include one or more of these as standard:

Jump Jets Triple energy cost to move, but can reach inaccessible places.

Lights External spotlights. Allow for faster movement, reduce/ negate targeting penalty at close range at night.

Night Vision Sensors Allow for faster movement, reduce/ negate targeting penalties at night.

Sensor Array Improve initiative throws by 1.

Smoke Launcher Penalise attacks (both by the mech and against it by 2). Disperses after 3/2/1 rounds in calm/gentle/ strong wind.

B Senzangakona-class Heavy Mech

Intended for direct assaults on hard targets. Improved armour plating and heavy armament compared to a standard mech.

Weapons
- 2x Mech laser
- 2 belt-fed automatic rifles (10 combat rounds of ammunition, normal attributes as personal weapons)

Enlarged powerplant 75 instead of 50 power points

Heavy armour More favourable damage table

Modules
- Smoke launcher
- Night Vision Sensors
- Sensor Array

d6	Front	Side	Rear
1	Breach	Breach	Breach
2	Visor	Fuel	Fuel
3	Gun	Motor	Motor
4	Gun	Power	Power
5	Module	Gun	Hatch
6	None	None	Module

C Mpande-class Combat Mech

When you say “mech” to the people in [redacted] Sector, this is what they imagine. Decently fast, decently armoured, decently armed.

Weapons
- 1 Mech Laser
- 1 belt-fed automatic rifle (10 combat rounds of ammunition, normal attributes as personal weapons)

Modules

- Lights
- Smoke Launcher

D Dingane-class Combat Mech

A Mpande-class with a mech gun instead of the laser.

Weapons

- 1 Mech Gun
- 1 belt-fed automatic rifle (10 combat rounds of ammunition, normal attributes as personal weapons)

Modules

- Lights
- Smoke Launcher

E Ndlela-class Scout Mech

Lightly armoured, but faster. Maximum speed is 100km/hr on most terrain. Not intended to stay in a fight, but should still be able to deal with infantry patrols or similar low-level threats.

Armour As Ablat

Weapons

- 1 Mech Gun

Modules

- Night Vision Sensors
- Sensor Array
- Jump Jets

Design Notes

The idea underlying this document to have as few rules as possible but make mechs consequentially different to just being infantry. This is made by having them be much harder to hit, and even once hit to damage, difficult to damage unless special or peer weapons are used.

In general, mech weapons do a little extra damage (1D) and have better chances to hit at long and very long range. To offset this, they have worse chances to hit at close and short range. The base weapon statlines are adjusted to be slightly better than the standard infantry versions.

Damage does not track hit points directly, but there are relatively few ways to really kill mechs (the powerplant blowing up or killing the pilot) and those need an additional low-probability throw to achieve. It is more likely that a mech suffers a mission kill from disabling the weapons or a mobility kill from damage disabling motors, the powerplant or rupturing the fuel tanks. Most systems or modules on a mech can take two hits before being disabled, but which are hit is randomised. Subsystems usually have one entry per facing, so we can expect a given location to take ~3.77 rolls on average before they are disabled.

Using “combat armour” allows the numbers to remain roughly in-line with personal combat, while still being difficult to make effective hits on. Downgrading to something like Ablat is a good way to model lighter armour (see the Ndlela-class) since effective hits will be easier to achieve. Tougher armour was modeled for the Senzangakona-class Mech by reducing the effect of hits: no damage is taken from 16% of hits.
